

POLI 100

American Democracy in Changing Times

Fall 2025

Tuesdays and Thursdays

3:30pm-4:45pm

210 Gardner Hall

Graduate Instructor: Allen Wilson

Email: awils@unc.edu

Office Hours: Tuesdays and Thursdays, 2:00pm-3:00pm; Fridays, 11:00am-12:00pm; or by appointment

Office Hours Location: Hamilton (Pauli Murray) Hall 459 or via Zoom

Course Description and Objectives

This course is designed to enhance your overall understanding of how American democracy functions so that you may become better, more informed citizens and scholars. We will discuss the Constitution's principles and its changes over time; the institutions that allow for and are entrusted to uphold democratic republicanism; and finally, how the American public forms political preferences and holds (or does not hold) elected officials accountable.

The primary goal of this course is to ensure that you can think critically about American government and politics. Doing so will require understanding the “why” behind the Constitution and American government. This goes beyond memorizing the number of justices needed to issue a writ of certiorari or how many Senate votes are needed to invoke cloture. Though these facts are important to understanding American politics at a rudimentary level, this course will seek to synthesize this information in a higher-level discussion to understand the underlying dynamics of American governance.

This thinking extends beyond American government and the Constitution to individual citizens as well. One cannot have a complete picture of how American democracy works without understanding the motivations and decision-making of those from whom government derives its authority—the governed. Doing so will require understanding a bit of psychology and human behavior and a bit of political parties' history in America, as well as how these dovetail with institutional rules of electoral competition. In doing so, we will often discuss the current dynamics of political opinion and participation in the United States.

The final goal of the course is to give you a better understanding of political science as a discipline. As this is an introductory course in political science, we will read some seminal works in the field and use them to inform our discussions of both the in-class course material and to understand the complexities of modern American democracy. In doing so, I ask that you engage deeply and critically with the readings. By the end of this course, you will all be more informed citizens and future scholars. Finally, I hope you begin to see politics as something that can be systematically studied and understood yet at the same time, continuously surprising and, at times, awe-inspiring.

Office Hours and Communicating with Me

I will be available for office hours from 2pm-3pm on Tuesdays and Thursdays and 11am-12pm on Fridays in 459 Hamilton (Pauli Murray) Hall, provided classes are in session. If you can't make it during that time, please send me an email, and we will schedule a Zoom meeting or a separate appointment. Please stop by if you have any questions or concerns about the course, especially regarding the writing assignments, or if you just want to talk about politics, political science, or anything else!

Please reach out to me via email (awils@unc.edu) at any time if you have a question about the course, assignments, or if you'd like to chat about politics or political science generally. I check my email daily, so I will typically respond to emails within 24 hours. But I will always respond to an email within 48 hours, with some grace for weekends. If I have not responded to your email within 48 hours, please send me a follow-up email! Sometimes emails get lost in my draft folder. And sometimes my dog distracts me, and I forget to respond to the email I just read!

Required Texts

You are not required to purchase a textbook for this class. I will post the relevant readings to Canvas. The readings for each class are listed on the course schedule below.

Grading Policy

I am sure you have heard and read these words many times, but grades do not define you. In many cases, grades do not matter. Only in certain circumstance will grades heavily affect your future career prospects. I am happy to talk at any time about my own experiences and give advice about grades, if it is solicited.

Having done a throat-clearing on that point, it is my hope to give everyone in this class an "A." Getting an "A" often requires hard work, dedication, and genuine understanding that comes

with deep engagement with the course material. However, you may not be taking this course to deeply engage with political science but rather as Gen. Ed. requirement. You also might not want to work too hard in the course. That means that you may opt to aim for a “B” or “C.” That is perfectly fine and is up to your discretion, and I will not hold this against you. If you ever have any questions about assignments, readings, or exams, I will be available for office hours on Tuesdays, Thursdays, and Fridays, and I will be available via Zoom and email as well. The grade distribution for assignments appears below as well as the grading scale.

- 15%: Attendance/Engagement
- 45%: Exams (3 in total)
 - o Lowest: 5%
 - o Median: 15%
 - o Highest: 25%
- 20%: Reflections (3 in total; 1 is optional)
- 20%: Final paper

A 93-100, A- 90-92, B+ 87-89, B 83-86, B- 80-82, C+ 77-79, C 73-76, C- 70-72, D+ 67-69, D 63-66, D- 60-62, F 59 and below.

Attendance and Engagement

This class will cover a broad array of topics, and we will dive as deeply into each of them as time allows. That means that active attendance and engagement are required for this course. If you do not attend class regularly, it is likely that you will fall behind. If you are not prepared for class (e.g., having done the required readings), are distracted (e.g., by social media), or generally not paying attention, success in the class will be difficult. Minor infractions may be given grace, but repeatedly missing class or being disengaged is more difficult to overlook.

Attendance and engagement, then, makes up 15% of your grade as an incentive. Excluding syllabus day and exam days, we will only meet in class a little over 20 times during the course of the semester. Therefore, I would strongly prefer that you **not miss more than 3 class sessions**. However, I can be flexible given extenuating circumstances. If you must miss more than 3 class sessions, please communicate this in writing. The primary reason for this is that you might fall behind with too many absences, and we may need to meet individually to make sure steady progress is maintained.

Engagement is broadly defined. Most days of class are accompanied by a required reading or two, which will be highly relevant to class. While you will not be directly tested on

the material in these readings that we do not discuss in class, the quality of the class depends on your willingness to read these materials before each class and your preparation to discuss them. Please do not engage with social media, text others, shop online, etc., in class. Laptops are absolutely fine to use in class if you would like, but I reserve the right to change this policy if there is too much disengagement.

To dispel with ambiguities regarding grading, I have included some descriptions of grades corresponding to attendance and engagement below. As with all grades for the course, you might find the requirements for an “A” to be too demanding. You may opt for the workload of a “B” or “C” as you wish, and I will not hold this against you in any way.

1. Those with an “A” grade regularly attend class (miss no more than 3 class sessions) and display clear engagement through 1) reading course materials before class, 2) consistently offering relevant, insightful comments or questions about topics in class, and 3) actively participating in group discussions and activities.
2. Those with a “B” grade somewhat regularly attend class (4-5 absences) and display at least 2 out of the 3 engagement descriptions listed above.
3. Those with a “C” grade sporadically attend class (6-8 absences) and display at least 1 out of the 3 engagement descriptions listed above.

Exams

The bulk of your grade in this class consists of three exams that are collectively worth 45% of your grade. Exams are a useful way of gauging your knowledge and understanding of the course material. However, I understand that they can be imperfect assessments of knowledge at times, and it is not my intention for your grade to be significantly harmed because of a bad performance on a single exam. Indeed, there are many valid reasons why this might be the case. For example, learning is often strongly correlated with interest in the topic, and some topics in the course simply may not capture your imagination. There also might be extenuating individual circumstances that cause you to perform poorly for one exam.

To alleviate these drawbacks and pressures of exams, I have opted to adopt the following grading policies. First, all exams (including the final) are non-cumulative, meaning they will only cover the material related to the corresponding third of the course, unless the material is overlapping and mentioned in class again. Second, the exams will likely consist of a mixture of short answer and multiple-choice questions to gauge both the breadth and depth of your knowledge of the course material.

Third, the exams are unequally weighted to give you the best chance to succeed. Out of the three exams, your highest score will account for 25% of your grade in the course. The median of the three grades will account for 15%, and the lowest score will only be worth 5% of your grade. **However, you must take all three exams.** That means that if you are happy with your first two exam grades and do not wish to take the final exam, you still must do so. Otherwise, you will receive an Incomplete (IN) grade for the course. Please reach out if you have questions about this. I will update the weighted grades after each exam.

If you struggle with exams generally, I highly encourage you to reach out to the Learning Center on campus (information listed below). The Learning Center is completely free (with your tuition dollars, of course) and can be helpful in developing studying plans and habits. While they will not be helpful in studying the specific material in this course, they can help with general test-taking strategies for this and all courses at UNC.

Reflections

To incentivize deeper critical thinking and engagement with the course materials, you will be required to write two Reflections during the term. These will be worth 20% of your grade. Reflections should engage deeply with one of the required readings in the corresponding third of the term while synthesizing and connecting the reading to contemporary politics. The purpose of this assignment is for you to dive deeper into aspects of the course you find interesting and spend time synthesizing this information with the real world of current politics. If you would like to complete a Reflection on one of the *suggested readings* instead of one of the required readings, please make sure to get direct approval from me before doing so.

You may complete a maximum of one Reflection before each exam, for a total of three Reflections over the course of the term. Of these three opportunities, you will be required to submit two Reflections. If you opt to complete all three Reflection opportunities, your grade will be an average of the top two grades on your Reflections. I will then add a maximum of 5 bonus points to your overall Reflections grade, depending on the quality of the lowest scoring submission. Each Reflection should be 2 pages minimum, double-spaced, Times New Roman font. Please see Canvas for a more detailed outline of expectations for this assignment.

Final Paper

The final paper will be 5 pages minimum, double-spaced, Times New Roman font and will be due on the last day of class: Tuesday, December 2. By the end of September, I will give you a list of several prompts from which you can choose your final paper topic so that you will have ample time to complete a high-quality paper. Again, I will post a more detailed assignment to Canvas outlining the expectations for this assignment, which we will discuss in class.

You might be asking yourself, why do we still have a paper assignment in the age of AI? Can't ChatGPT just do this for us? Generative AI is exceedingly useful in many respects, but it cannot be used as a substitute for learning how to communicate through writing (see AI policy below). In whatever field you decide to go into, it is likely that you will have to learn to effectively communicate your ideas after critically thinking through some problem. LLMs, while useful, are not a high-quality substitute for learning how to do this yourself.

At their best, writing assignments in college should help you learn to write, and to write well, something that very few classes focus on. I care quite a bit about this. I tend to give a lot of feedback on written assignments. Indeed, past students in my classes often remark on the amount and quality of the feedback I give. I do this so that you can learn to organize your thoughts effectively through writing, an immensely important aspect of social science, specifically (and in life, generally). To incentivize high-quality work, I've included a deadline for a rough draft on November 13 in the course schedule. Submitting this is completely optional, and you may submit either a working outline of your paper or a rough draft of the paper as it currently stands. I am providing you this option so that I can give you feedback before the due date, so please take advantage of it!

If you struggle with writing or want someone to look over your work, the Writing Center on campus is very helpful and is free of charge (again, with your tuition dollars), just like the Learning Center. I highly recommend them as a resource to help organize your paper and think through how to effectively communicate your ideas. And I am always available during office hours or via email if you want to think through ideas or have any questions!

Late Work

Once again, this course requires active engagement. That includes in-class and out-of-class work. However, unforeseen daily circumstances may prevent high-quality work from being completed by the due date listed on the course schedule. Trust me, I understand that these things happen. At the same time, for you (completing assignments) and I (grading assignments) to complete our relevant tasks in a timely manner, the due dates are relatively inflexible.

So, I will allow **three full grace days for all assignments**, excluding exams, which must be given and completed during the exam period. You do not need to provide any justification for using grace days. This should cover nearly all circumstances that should arise, but if there are particularly extenuating circumstances, please reach out to me (several days ahead of time, if possible) so that we can make the necessary arrangements. Work submitted more than three full days (72 hours) after the original due date will be considered late and will be penalized by 10 points per day that the work is considered late.

Research Activity Requirement

Students enrolled in this course are required to participate in the Department of Political Science research activities as part of their course requirement. A principal goal of the requirement is for students to gain an appreciation of how political science research works, while simultaneously acquiring new knowledge about areas of the discipline that they may not encounter in their Poli courses.

The research requirement is administered by the Political Science Subject Pool (PSSP) Administrators. To satisfy the research requirement, you must complete eight (8) credits of research by participating in actual political science research studies. Research studies are typically research experiments or surveys. Typically, each study's completion satisfies one (1) credit towards the requirement; occasionally, a study will count for more than one credit. The research requirement is fulfilled when eight (8) credits are earned. Students can participate in research studies and track their requirement fulfillment status by logging into their PSSP Portal (<https://tarheels.live/psspparticipants/>) using their UNC Onyen and password. (The Portal will become active in October.)

Students who object or fail to total eight credits through participation in research studies will be given the opportunity to fulfill the research requirement by writing a 800-word research-oriented reaction paper for a current events article listed on the PSSP Portal.

The total time commitment to complete the research requirement should not exceed 3 hours. The research requirement does not substitute for other course requirements, nor does it generate extra credit. Failure to satisfy the research requirement will result in an incomplete grade (IN) that will be removed only upon satisfaction of the requirement. For additional information and contacts, please email pssp@unc.edu.

IRB Contact Information:

CB 7097

720 Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd.

Bldg # 385, Second Floor

Chapel Hill, NC 27599-7097

Ph: 919-966-3113

Fax: 919-966-7879

AI Policy

Carolina students are expected to follow these AI guidelines:

1. AI can help you think, not think for you. You may be able to use these tools to brainstorm ideas, research topics, and analyze problems, but you must decide what's appropriate and accurate. Please ask me if you have questions.
2. Engage responsibly with AI. You must evaluate AI-generated outputs for potential biases, limitations, inaccuracies, false output, and ethical implications. Do not put personal or confidential data into these tools.
3. The use of AI must be open and documented. You should declare, explain, and cite any use of AI in the creation of your work using applicable standards (e.g., APA, MLA, course guidelines). Understand that you are ultimately 100% responsible for your final product.
4. Follow specific AI guidelines in this syllabus. If you are unsure, check with me.
Guidance offered in this syllabus would be referenced should an issue be referred to Student Conduct for alleged academic misconduct.

If you are using AI to correct spelling, punctuation, grammar, etc. in your existing writing, that is completely fine. In fact, I highly encourage you to use a program like Grammarly (non-generative version) for these purposes.

AI may not ever be used, however, to do the writing for you. If I suspect that you have written a paper in this class, in whole or in part, using generative AI, I will take appropriate actions to refer the matter to the Office of Student Conduct. Please do not make me do this. If you are struggling with the course material and/or assignments, please reach out to me. It is not worth using generative AI if it expels you from the University. A lower grade than you wanted can be overcome, but expulsion stays on your permanent record (in life and in school).

As with all parts of the syllabus, I reserve the right to extend or revise this section of the syllabus at any time. Specific assignments will include additional requirements reporting standards for AI usage as needed.

Writing Center

For free feedback on any course writing projects, check out UNC's Writing Center. Writing Center coaches can assist with any writing project, including multimedia projects and application essays, at any stage of the writing process. You don't even need a draft to come visit. To schedule a 45-minute appointment, review quick tips, or request written feedback online, visit [UNC's Writing Center online.](#)

Learning Center

Want to get the most out of this course or others this semester? Visit [UNC's Learning Center](#) to make an appointment or register for an event. Their free, popular programs will help you optimize your academic performance. Try academic coaching, peer tutoring, STEM support, ADHD/LD services, workshops and study camps, or review tips and tools available on the website.

University Attendance Policy

University Policy: As stated in the University's [Class Attendance Policy](#), no right or privilege exists that permits a student to be absent from any class meetings, except for these University Approved Absences:

1. Authorized University activities: [University Approved Absence Office \(UAAO\)](#) website provides information and [FAQs for students](#) and [FAQs for faculty](#) related to University Approved Absences
2. Disability/religious observance/pregnancy/short-term military service, as required by law and approved by the [Equal Opportunity and Compliance Office](#) (EOC), or in the case of short-term military service, the Dean of Students
3. Significant health condition and/or personal/family emergency as approved by the [Office of the Dean of Students](#), [Gender Violence Service Coordinators](#), and/or the [Equal Opportunity and Compliance Office](#) (EOC).

Code of Conduct

1. All students are expected to adhere to University policy and follow the guidelines of the UNC Code of Conduct. Additional information can be found at <https://studentconduct.unc.edu/>.

University Compliance Office - Accommodations

University Compliance Office (UCO) Accommodations Team ([Accommodations – UNC Equal Opportunity and Compliance](#)) receives requests for accommodations for disability, pregnancy and related conditions, and sincerely held religious beliefs and practices through the University's Policy on Accommodations. UCO Accommodations team determines eligibility and reasonable accommodations consistent with state and federal laws.

Counseling and Psychological Services

UNC-Chapel Hill is strongly committed to addressing the mental health needs of a diverse student body. The [Heels Care Network](#) website is a place to access the many mental health resources at Carolina. CAPS is the primary mental health provider for students, offering timely access to consultation and connection to clinically appropriate services. Go to the [CAPS website](#) or visit their facilities on the third floor of the Campus Health building for an initial evaluation to learn more. Students can also call CAPS 24/7 at 919-966-3658 for immediate assistance.

Title IX Resources

Any student who is impacted by discrimination, harassment, interpersonal (relationship) violence, sexual violence, sexual exploitation, or stalking is encouraged to seek resources on campus or in the community. Reports can be made [online to the EOC](#) or by contacting the [University's Title IX Coordinator](#), Elizabeth Hall, or the [Report and Response Managers](#) in the Equal Opportunity and Compliance Office. Please note that I am designated as a Responsible Employee, which means I must report to the EOC any information I receive about the forms of misconduct listed in this paragraph. If you'd like to speak with a confidential resource, those include Counseling and Psychological Services, the University's Ombuds Office, and the [Gender Violence Services Coordinators](#). Additional resources are available at safe.unc.edu.

Diversity Statement

Democracy requires citizens to understand that each person interacts with the world from different perspectives and experiences. As such, I regard diversity as a high ideal to be pursued, and we will model this in the classroom. This class is an inclusive space for any and all races, gender identities, national origins, ethnicities, religions, social classes, ages, sexual orientations, political backgrounds, ideologies, or physical and learning abilities, among others.

Additionally, diversity of thought is essential to the furtherance of knowledge. This diversity flows from each of us, from each of the categories listed above, and from each of our own experiences in life, so this class will highlight diversity where possible to further strengthen the academic experience in the classroom.

Course Schedule

Below is a schedule for the course with both the topics that will be covered in class as well as the readings that should be done before each day of class. All readings will be posted on Canvas. I

reserve the right to make changes to the schedule listed below and to any other part of the syllabus as needed. A relevant key to the right-hand column is listed below as well.

As mentioned before, you must complete at least two Reflections over the course of the term. The readings eligible to be the subject of a Reflection are required readings (in plain text format), not suggested readings (in italics). However, if you feel that a suggested reading stands out and you'd like to write a Reflection on it, that's probably fine too, but you must clear it with me first. You may not do so without first getting approval from me.

**Readings that are required before class are in plain text format. This includes links to articles or videos. Reflections may be based on any one of these materials that you choose.*

***Assignments are in bold and have an asterisk next to them. Assignments should be completed and turned in by 11:59pm on the date listed.*

****Suggested readings are in italics and are not required, though they may be helpful to understanding course material or introducing related concepts. I will often reference the suggested readings as we discuss the topic for each day, but any material that is necessary for exam assessments will be mentioned explicitly in class.*

Date	Topics	Readings and Assignments
8/19 (Tuesday)	Syllabus & Introduction to the Course	<i>Syllabus</i>
8/21 (Thursday)	Theories of Democracy & Citizen Responsibilities	Achen and Bartels, Democracy for Realists, Ch. 1 <i>Bernard Berelson, "Democratic Theory and Public Opinion"</i> - <i>Read and understand highlighted portions. You may skim the rest.</i>
8/26 (Tuesday)	Constitution & Founding	<i>U.S. Constitution</i> <i>Declaration of Independence</i>

8/28 (Thursday)	Constitution & Founding (cont'd)	Federalist 10 - <i>The Federalist Papers</i> can be dense at times. I recommend trying to read it as written, then looking up a good summary or two in case there are some points you might have overlooked. Please come to class ready to discuss.
9/2 (Tuesday)	Constitution & Founding (cont'd)	Federalist 51 - See note on <i>Federalist 10</i> .
9/4 (Thursday)	Civil Rights	<i>Gettysburg Address & Emancipation Proclamation</i>
9/9 (Tuesday)	Civil Rights (cont'd) & Civil Liberties	Letter from a Birmingham Jail <i>Brown v. Board of Education (1954)</i>
9/11 (Thursday)	Civil Liberties (cont'd)	<i>Lawless and Fox, "What happens if you're charged with a crime?"</i> *Reflection #1 is Due
9/16 (Tuesday)	Catch-up/Review Day	
9/18 (Thursday)	*Exam 1	*Print off the "Exam Materials" document located on Canvas and bring this to class.
9/23 (Tuesday)	Supreme Court	Federalist 78 - See note on <i>Federalist 10</i> .
9/25 (Thursday)	Supreme Court (cont'd)	<i>Supreme Court Procedure - SCOTUSblog</i>
9/30 (Tuesday)	Presidency	<i>The Green Lantern Theory of the Presidency, explained Vox</i>
10/2 (Thursday)	Presidency (cont'd) & Bureaucracy	<i>Kernell et al., Ch. 8</i>
10/7 (Tuesday)	University Well-being Day: <u>No Class</u>	Take a stroll outside and touch some grass!

10/9 (Thursday)	Congress & The Legislative Process	<i>How a Bill Becomes a Law: Crash Course Government and Politics #9</i> <i>Lawless and Fox, “How doesn’t a bill become a law?”</i>
10/14 (Tuesday)	In-class Congress Activity	Please make sure to attend class this day.
10/16 (Thursday)	Fall Break: <u>No Class</u>	Enjoy the fall weather and admire the beautiful trees!
10/21 (Tuesday)	Political Parties in Congress	Aldrich, Why Parties?, Ch. 1 Gerrymandering: - <i>Gerrymandering and redistricting, explained: How political parties are trying to redraw congressional maps Vox</i>
10/23 (Thursday)	Political Parties in Congress (cont’d) Catch-Up/Review Day	Lee, Insecure Majorities, Ch. 2 - Also read pp. 203-209 <i>Binder, “The Dynamics of Legislative Gridlock”</i> *Reflection #2 is due
10/28 (Tuesday)	*Exam 2	*Print off the “Exam Materials” document located on Canvas and bring this to class.
10/30 (Thursday)	Public Opinion and Democracy	<i>V.O. Key, Public Opinion and American Democracy, Ch. 1</i>
11/4 (Tuesday)	Political Opinion Formation	Lay et al., “Partisanship on the Playground” <i>Strother et al., “College roommates have a modest but significant influence on each other’s political ideology”</i>

11/6 (Thursday)	Parties & Polarization	Hetherington, “Resurgent Mass Partisanship” <i>Timeline of US Political Parties</i>
11/11 (Tuesday)	Parties & Polarization (cont’d)	Mason, Uncivil Agreement, Ch. 5 <i>Tyler and Iyengar, “Learning to Dislike Your Opponents”</i>
11/13 (Thursday)	Parties & Polarization (cont’d)	<i>Hetherington, New Directions, Ch. 7</i> *Rough Draft is Due (Optional)
11/18 (Tuesday)	Campaigns, Elections, & Political Participation	Democracy for Realists, Ch. 5
11/20 (Thursday)	Campaigns, Elections, & Political Participation (cont’d)	<i>Minority Rule: First Past the Post Voting</i> *Reflection #3 is due
11/25 (Tuesday)	Campaigns, Elections, & Political Participation (cont’d)	<i>Democracy for Realists Ch. 2</i>
11/27 (Thursday)	Thanksgiving Break: <u>No Class</u>	Eat some turkey (veggie options included), relax, and take a nap!
12/2 (Tuesday)	Catch-up/Review Day	*Final Paper is due
<u>12/11</u> <u>(Thursday)</u>	Final Exam: 4-7pm	*Final Exam - We will meet in our normal classroom (GA 210) at 4pm on 12/11 for the final exam. The exam will end at 7pm, though it should not take you that long to complete it. *Print off the “Exam Materials” document located on Canvas and bring this to class.